

The Firefly Lanterns

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



The Firefly Lanterns

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

Tonight is the summer Lantern Festival in the Lantern Village. Every year the paper lanterns glow, and the whole village dances under their warm light. But something is wrong. The lanterns will not light. They hang grey and dark in the evening air.

The reason is a quiet one. Inside each lantern lives a shy little Firefly Spirit, and tonight every one of them has flown off to hide. They are deep in the Whispering Bamboo Grove, in the dark, too timid to come out.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper calls you to her side. "You two have wise heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you go to the grove and gently coax the firefly spirits back, so our festival can glow?"

She gives you three gifts: a paper lantern, a ball of red thread, and a soft, sweet rice cake. Then she smiles. "Up in the hills we do not win by being loud or strong. We win by being wise, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Will you carry Wisdom, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Dark Bamboo

You climb the path to the Whispering Bamboo Grove. The tall stalks click and whisper in the wind. It is dark in here, and very still. Somewhere close, tiny lights blink on and off, then hide again. The firefly spirits are here, but they are shy.

A russet fox steps softly from the green shadows. It is Kon the Fox, with bright, clever eyes and a little leaf on his head. He gives you a friendly wink.

The spirits are timid. What kind thing could you do? Could you move gently and speak softly? You have a sweet rice cake to share. Could you sit very still and let them come to you?

When you are calm and kind, one little light drifts near. Then another. Soon a cloud of tiny golden fireflies floats around you, no longer afraid. "Well done," whispers Kon. "They trust you now."

Stop 2: The Lantern Path

The fireflies will follow you home, but only if they feel safe. A long path of empty paper lanterns leads down the hill to the village. If you light them in the right order, a gentle path of light will guide the shy spirits all the way.

But which lantern first? They come in many sizes, and your ball of red thread runs from one to the next, tying them in a line.

How will you light them so the spirits feel safe? Could you go from the smallest lantern to the biggest? Could you simply follow the red thread from lantern to lantern? Could you ask Kon the Fox for a hint?

When you find the gentle order and light them one by one, a soft road of golden light opens up. The little fireflies bob along it happily, following you down the hill.

Stop 3: The Great Lantern

At the top of the festival square stands the Great Lantern, the biggest of them all. To light it, the shyest little firefly of all must fly up inside. But this one is the most timid, and it hangs

back, trembling, afraid of the great dark lantern.

This is not a fight. The little firefly just needs to feel brave.

What could you say to help it? Could you speak in a soft, calm voice? Could you tell it that you believe in it, and that you will be right here? Could you show it how brave it already is?

When you cheer it on with calm and kindness, the little firefly takes a deep breath and flies up. The Great Lantern fills with warm light, the brightest of all.

The Festival Glows

One by one, every lantern in the village glows golden. The dark is gone. The firefly spirits swirl and dance in the warm air, looping in happy circles, no longer shy at all.

The whole village cheers and laughs and begins to dance. Drums beat softly. The lanterns sway like a sky full of small warm moons.

When morning comes, warm Amaterasu the Sun-Kami lifts over the hills and smiles down at you. You did it together. You were wise, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes finding tiny shy firefly spirits hiding in a dark bamboo grove at night, their glows barely flickering.



Two small heroes lighting a winding row of paper lanterns along a village path at night, each glowing warm gold as a firefly spirit settles in.



A friendly fox and two small heroes gently coaxing the shyest firefly spirit toward a great unlit festival lantern.



A whole village festival glowing with lit paper lanterns and swirling firefly spirits, two small heroes cheering, a silver moon above.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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